persons gave off an impression that the Kumbha Mela was flooded with people and the authorities were showing off their management skills. However, due to the powerful visuals presented by predisposed media, the local government came across as completely tone deaf to the COVID-19 situation in the country.

Second, as Swami Avdeshanand Giri Maharaj also expressed, even in other countries, religious sentiments were duly considered; in Germany, for example, Chancellor Angela Merkel reversed her decision to enforce a lockdown to accommodate Easter gatherings in 2020.[13] In Israel, after over a year of lockdown restrictions, a religious festival which drew thousands of ultra-Orthodox Jews went out of hand, resulting in mass stampede that led to over 45 deaths and over 150 injuries. Both are pertinent examples which demonstrate the need for governments to carefully consider deep-set religious belief systems which form the fabric of that particular society.

A few days after the second snan held on 12 April, the head of Mahanirvani Akhada, Mahamandaleshwar Kapil Das died due to COVID-19. Despite this, the ascetics and seers were not making any official commitments to withdraw, possibly due to revered religious processes being paramount for them as compared to loss of their own lives. As the infections began to submerge public health systems in the area, undercutting all government estimates, the prime minister eventually had to step in to request the head of the Juna Akhara, Acharya Mahamandaleshwar Avdheshanand Giri, to withdraw from the Kumbh in greater public health interest. After the prime minister's appeal, the Juna Akhara wound up their activities and pledged to observe the other two snans symbolically. Taking Juna Akhara's example, the other akharas followed suit.

However, the damage done in terms of the infection spreading unchecked, the lives lost to COVID-19 and the public outrage on seeing images of millions grossly violating COVID-19 protocols was irreparable. While we saw similar events taking place in Israel, Easter events in Germany and other parts of the world, the media projection of the Kumbh was specially hateful and criticism for the government for allowing such an event even more repugnant. On the global stage, at a time when Hinduism is fast gaining popularity as one of the most tolerant and peaceful religions especially amongst the 'woke generation', the far-Left sections of the media seemed to go out of their way to paint the Kumbh as an abhorrent ritual responsible for the second surge of the virus in the country. Slowly but